

Kamron Saniee

Filmmaker, Composer, and Researcher

Education

Columbia University. PhD Fellowship and M.A. (2019 – 2022)
École Normale Supérieure, Paris. Visiting Student (2011 – 2012)
Princeton University. A.B. with Highest Honors (2009 – 2013)

Artistic Practice & Residencies (Selected)

The Hole (2026). Wrote the original screenplay for a narrative short film (in pre-production).
A.I. Stars (2026). Wrote, directed, and edited an award-winning documentary short/essay film on the cinematic prehistory of synthetic actors. Awards: Best Short Documentary (Cine Paris Film Festival); Best Documentary (Brooklyn International Short Festival); Jury Favorite (A Lyte in the Dark Film Festival); Honorable Mention (DaVinci Film Festival, LA)
LUCA (2025), Management Gallery. Composed the original soundtrack for artist Anastasia Komar's sculpture installation. Soundtrack highlighted by the New York Times in "*What to see in NYC Galleries in May 2025*" with a review by Seph Rodney.
Angel Express (Album, 2024). Published by NYC label unseele. Featured in The Fader's "*Songs You Need In Your Life*" with a review by Raphael Helfand.
Euphoric Studies (Album, 2021). Published by SVS Records (DE). Recommended by Resident Advisor in April 2021, with a review by Matthew McDermott.
Red Bull Music Academy 2016. One of 39 international artists selected for the competitive residency, held in Montreal.
The Lot Radio (2017 – 2019). Hosted a monthly radioshow for classical and electronic music. Curated live classical concerts.
The Spatial Sound Institute, Budapest (2016): Developed and presented a spatial sound composition for the 4DSOUND system in collaboration with German artists Maxim Wolzyn and Lukas Rehm.

Curation

Instruments of Desire (2026): a four-part film and chamber music series at The Roxy Cinema on classical music cinema, featuring films *All the Mornings of the World*, *The Red Violin*, *The Draughtman's Contract*, and *Târ*, with musical intro performances by Marc Armitano Domingo, Chili Ekman, The New York Recorder Ensemble, the Candide Quartet, and a film introduction by Broey Deschanel.
All the Mornings of the World (2026): Organized the first NYC screening of Alain Corneau's Baroque classic in 20 years at Roxy Cinema New York, featuring a musical introduction by viola da gambist Marc Armitano Domingo
Spatial Music (2015 – 2024): Organized multiple events and installations for spatial and multichannel music at venues including Fridman Gallery, The Knockdown Center, Future Space, and the Yokohama Performing Arts Meeting.
K.O.! at The Shaolin Temple (2023–2024): Organized and curated live music concerts taking place at the USA Shaolin Temple in Chinatown, Manhattan, featuring artists including Aaron David Ross, Pictureplane, Dasychira, and Bsnyea.

Teaching & Guest Lectures

Parsons School of Design, The New School. Part-Time Faculty (2023 – 2024)
Developed and co-taught *Immersive Soundscapes*, a studio course introducing spatial audio and sonic phenomenology. Supervised individual and group projects, guiding students through thematic spatial sound composition.
Columbia University. Graduate Student Worker / Teaching Assistant (2019 – 2022)
Yale University, Center for Collaborative Arts and Media. Invited lecture on my spatial music practice (2018)
IKKM / Bauhaus University, Weimar, DE. Invited lecture in the conference *The Algorithm as Cultural Technique* (2018)
NEW INC, The New Museum, New York. Invited lecture on audio AI for the critical technology collective ArtSec (2015)

Selected Industry Experience

Hypelist New York *Director of Machine Learning* (2024 – Present)
Designed and deployed algorithms for cultural discovery for a fast-growing social media platform.

Harmonic Mean LLC New York *Founder and Chief Applied Scientist* (2024 – Present)
Creative tech development: Released *xoFocus*, an iPhone app exploring AI-enhanced reading with intelligent highlighting.
Consulting: Engaged as a fractional director and advisor for multiple technology/media startups and venture studios.

TikTok / ByteDance New York *Senior/Staff Data Scientist (Content)* (2022 – 2024)
Conducted the first semantic analysis of viral music trends using internal speech and audio models.
Engineered models that fused algorithmic distribution with creator-centric operations, notably amplifying the Cannes Film Festival to a globally promoted event on TikTok following signoff by global leadership.

International Brain Lab New York *Researcher* (2021 – 2022)

Researched the decoding of neural activity with machine learning to predict behavior, contributing to the development of open-source tools for neurophysiology. Publications in Neuromatch conference proceedings and Nature Methods.

Selected Publications and Patents

Nature Methods (2024): "Lightning Pose: improved animal pose estimation via semi-supervised learning."

Nature Methods (2023): "A modular architecture for organizing, processing and sharing neurophysiology data."

Neuromatch (2021). "Modelling C. elegans neural activity with Bayesian neural networks."

U.S. Patent (2021): "Data-driven features via signal clustering" (No. 11055319).

SIAM Undergraduate Research Journal (2007): "A Simple Expression For Multivariate Lagrange Interpolation."

"On the possibility of a Metrischwille for spatial systems" (2013). Nova Organa Journal of Architecture, Princeton.

Kamron Saniee is a composer

Kamron Saniee is a composer, writer, and machine learning researcher from New Jersey, based in New York City. Trained as a classical violinist and composer, he has supported his artistic practice by working as a machine learning scientist since 2013. As a composer, he is interested in repurposing neoclassical compositional techniques with electronic instruments. His musical output and collaborations have received support by The New York Times, Red Bull Music Academy, The Fader, and Resident Advisor, and shown at venues such as Fridman Gallery and Management in New York, The Spatial Sound Institute in Budapest, and The Performing Arts Meetup in Yokohama. He is a student at The Writer's Studio in NYC and developing a screenplay on the supplanting of actors by AI. He has taught at Columbia and Parsons School of Design and given invited talks at the Yale Center for Collaborative Arts and the IKKM in Weimar, Germany.

Kamron Saniee is a composer, writer, and ML researcher from NJ, based in NYC. Trained as a classical violinist and composer, he has supported his artistic practice by working in the tech industry since 2013. As a composer, he is interested in repurposing neoclassical compositional techniques with electronic instruments. His music and collaborations have received support in The New York Times, Red Bull Music Academy, The Fader, and Resident Advisor, and shown at venues such as Fridman Gallery and Management in New York, Spatial Sound Institute in Budapest, and The Performing Arts Meetup in Yokohama. He is currently studying narrative composition at The Writer's Studio in New York and developing a screenplay on the supplanting of actors by AI. He has taught at Columbia and Parsons School of Design, and given talks at Yale and the IKKM/Bauhaus University in Weimar, Germany.

Please describe your artistic practice, including how your work engages with the themes of this residency. (max 250 words)

I am currently developing original narrative material taking the form of video essays and expository writing about the supplanting of human actors by AI. Tracing the representation of AI actors in film and exploring the status of synthetic personas in the public eye, the first version of this work will take the form of an audiovisual narrative exploring the history of synthetic personalities from the point of view of an AI actor. My work engages directly with the themes of this residency insofar as I make a livelihood by working within the AI industry. My firsthand knowledge of the technological basis, stakeholders, strategic positioning, and impact on populations informing my writing on AI actors. From a more speculative standpoint, composing the unique sonic personality for a nonhuman entity was a focus of my recent collaboration, LUCA, with sculptor Anastasia Komar (Management Gallery, 2025). Through both my livelihood in machine learning and artistic practice, I am uniquely positioned to explore questions surrounding AI ethics, as I expand on further below.

3 relevant examples of your work.

In an essay from Summer 2025 ('A.I. Stars, available on request), I explore the recent history of AI actors in the entertainment industry and probe the question of their continuity with the vertically integrated studio model in Old Hollywood. This essay is one input in my current work on a video essay on the subject of AI actors. Previously, I collaborated with the Russian New York-based sculptor Anastasia Komar to bring to life a

room-scale sculpture of an ancient blastoid, for which I composed a sonic personality. Expanding on affective criteria developed collaboratively, the 10-minute soundtrack adopted neoclassical motifs in an original composition featuring acoustic and electronic instruments to create a timeless yet thoroughly modern sonic presence. With LUCA, giving life to a nonhuman entity became part of my approach to thinking about synthetic personas—an approach I am now extending toward AI personas. Experimentation and deep artistic collaboration have been a constant throughout my creative practice. As a third example, I maintained a multi-year practice in spatial sound composition, utilizing original, self-designed algorithmic tools to create spatially synthesized sonic experiences. These works were often described by audience members as opening a completely unexplored dimension in the possibility of sound. In moving to new media, I aim to preserve the ethos of bold experimentation that characterized these earlier practices.

Please outline the work you would like to develop over the residency programme (max 300 words)

I would like to develop a short film exploring the history of the representation of AI actors in film and media, and the implications of their re-emergence in contemporary culture following the mass commercialization of generative AI technologies. The film will have a pedagogical and critical tone, drawing on the spirit of the critical video essays by Harun Farocki ('Labor in a Single Shot'), and reveal how current discussions on the displacement of human artists have been articulated and explored in film over the last 45 years. Looking forward, the narrative will draw from concepts in collective psychology and the technical basis of AI model training to question and investigate the status of AI personas as individuals. Once the narrative screenplay is developed, I aim to hire experienced talent (specifically, voice actors and live actors, as well as colorists and professional sound designers) including some who were personally involved in landmark commercial films of the late 90s and early 2000s that explored the concept of AI actors, creating continuity with the previous generation of popular narratives on this subject. Emphasis will be given in recruiting experienced and diverse talent in producing the film. I also aim to hire a consulting psychologist to refine certain applications of Jungian concepts that I am exploring in the working narrative.

Please outline how this idea critically engages intercultural ideas around AI and ethics (max 250 words)

The supplanting of human artistic labor by AI technologies is one of the defining issues of our time. It was a major sticking point of negotiations in the WGA and SAG-AFTRA strikes in 2023, and is becoming ever more real as prototype synthetic performers hit the market. Given my experience as an American employee at TikTok/ByteDance, a Chinese company which found profound resonance globally, a primary lens of my analysis and writing on this subject draws from culturally variable notions of the individual and the collective. Broadly speaking, in America and in the West, we have what can be perceived as a strong bias towards valuing the individual over the collective. Perhaps this also contributes to an underexploration of AI personas as collective bodies – more often, we are conditioned to think of them as individuals. Although these personas are frequently anthropomorphized, their composition as models trained on population and internet-scale data - in essence, on all recorded human experience - makes them intrinsically collective entities, despite their outward appearance and suggestive (but misleading) presentation as 'conscious' individuals. By exploring the psychology of the collective in non-Western cultures, and notions of the collective unconscious in Western critical traditions, we can better understand how to think politically, emotionally, and creatively about these synthetic entities, and how they may deepen our understanding of ourselves.

Please outline how your perspective might bring a unique lens to these themes? (max 200 words)

Since 2013, I have supported myself and self-funded my artistic practice by working in the machine learning industry. With first-hand experience spanning the emergence of deep learning in the early 2010s to the present-day commercialization of language models and generative AI, I am uniquely positioned to comment on the technical underpinnings, strategic narratives, and cultural potential of AI today. During two years working at TikTok/ByteDance, I witnessed firsthand how the capability of AI to discover and recommend content shapes the trends and narratives that fill daily life for hundreds of millions of people. On an entirely separate level, as an individual raised by parents from a non-Western culture (Iran), I am a lifelong practitioner of "second culture" perception, with a lived experience of interpreting one dominant shared culture from the external perspective of a foreign one. A quote by Bong Joon-Ho communicates this well: "AI is the beginning of our

understanding of what can only be done by humans.” I believe this mindset will help us conceive of an AI usage that enables us to travel deeper into the human experience, rather than away from it.

How would this residency impact your practice? (max 150 words)

Living in the most expensive city in the world and making a livelihood in an increasingly unstable technology industry, I have to be highly selective about the artistic opportunities that I invest my time in. Support in the form of paid residency backed by a household name institution would greatly assist in elevating my practice beyond what I can accomplish as an individual, facilitate collaborations with experienced talent, and allow me to take greater creative risks beyond the residency. Ultimately, I want to contribute to one of the most important societal discussions in our time through cultural production that draws on my unique background. I believe that this residency would provide a direct pathway for me to do so.

Please outline your proposed production budget breakdown, and timeline for delivery

Approximate timeline:

Screenplay finalization – 1 month

Sourcing production collaborators and talent – 1 month

Production (editing, necessary shoots, post-production) – 1 month.

Budget breakdown: Collaborators and talent (including fees for experienced DP, sound mixer, actors, and psychology consultant): £5000. Post-production (color grading, sound mixing): £1000. Contingencies (allocated for unforeseen technical or logistical shifts): £1500. Weeks 1&2: finalization of the narrative, shot list, and conceptual framework. Concurrent recruitment of talent prioritizing diversity. Weeks 3&4: principal production. Month 2: post-production, including feedback from the residency participants and associate network to ensure resonance with ethical and intercultural discourse. Month 3: preparation for digital exhibition and distribution, and development of supporting assets including a ‘making of’/proof-of-craft short foregrounding the collaborative process.

WEBSITE

Kamron Saniee’s compositions have been presented at Fridman Gallery, Management Gallery, The Knockdown Center, the USA Shaolin Temple, The Lot Radio, Elsewhere, La MaMa, and Nowadays, with international presentations at The Performing Arts Meetup in Yokohama, The Spatial Sound Institute in Budapest, and Collisions Festival in Munich. He has taught at Columbia University and Parsons School of Design, and lectured at Yale University, The New Museum, and the International Research Institute for Cultural Technologies and Media Philosophy at Bauhaus University, Weimar.

His solo and collaborative work has been featured in The New York Times (“What to see in N.Y.C. Galleries in May”, 2025), The Fader (“Songs You Need In Your Life”, 2024), and Resident Advisor (“RA Recommends” and “April’s Best Music”, 2021). In 2016, he was one of 39 international artist-producers selected for Red Bull Music Academy, held in Montreal.

He is currently in development on a narrative short film titled A.I. Stars, exploring the cinematic representation of synthetic actors. He is also authoring a series of short stories drawing on his experience working for TikTok during the national ban efforts in 2023-24.